

Commas in lists

Commas are used to separate words or phrases in a list. A good way to test if the comma is in the correct position is to replace it with one of the conjunctions *and* or *or*. If the sentence doesn't make sense with *and* or *or*, don't add a comma.

The **comma** is one of the **most misused** punctuation marks.

My interests are walking, flowers, birds, and gardening.

My interests are walking flowers, birds, and gardening.



Each interest is separated by a comma from another interest in the list.

The last word in the list is joined by a comma followed by the word *and*.

Since there is no comma separating *walking* and *flowers*, the interest is *walking flowers*.

The comma before the conjunction is known as a "serial comma" and is useful for preventing ambiguity.

Commas with adjectives

A list of adjectives in front of a noun can be treated in two different ways. If each adjective modifies the noun, add a comma to separate them. However, if an adjective describes a combination of words that come after, no comma is needed. There are two ways to check if a comma should be used.

First, if *and* can be added between the adjectives, a comma should be placed between them. Second, swap the adjectives. If the meaning hasn't changed, it's correct to use a comma to separate the adjectives.

I saw a yellow, flying saucer.

When the comma is placed here, each adjective describes the noun separately: The saucer is flying and yellow.



I saw a blue flying saucer.

With no comma, the adjective *blue* describes the *flying saucer*.



GLOSSARY

Adjective A word that describes a noun.

Conjunction A word used to connect phrases and clauses.

Main clause A group of words that contains a subject and a verb and makes complete sense on its own.

Noun A word that refers to a person, place, or thing.

Verb A word that describes an action.

• The **serial comma**, set after the second-to-last item of the list, is especially useful when there are two instances of ***and*** in a sentence. For example, "The blue, pink, and black-and-white flowers have grown."